



MONTHLY UPDATE

Digital divides: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-09 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

17 places. Every block below is carried verbatim from that place's own monthly update, where it was written, sourced and checked; nothing is written here.

ANGOLA · BOTSWANA · BURUNDI · DR CONGO · EGYPT · ESWATINI · GAMBIA · GHANA · GUINEA-BISSAU · KENYA
· MALAWI · MOZAMBIQUE · NIGER · NIGERIA · SENEGAL · SOUTH AFRICA · UGANDA

The place reports do not share one window; the period above is the range they span.

Angola

The satellite programme's antenna recovery and migration reached two more localities at the end of the month: a point restored at Quiage commune in Bengo, stated to serve five thousand residents, and [a connection at Quirimbo in Cuanza-Sul, delivered by startups of the national space programme](#). No running total of points restored or live accompanies the site-by-site reports, so the programme's reach can be dated and not sized.

Botswana

The creative sector was surveyed for a digital purpose. A two-day multistakeholder workshop in Gaborone [mapped Botswana's creative industries to shape a more inclusive digital future](#). A mapping is a starting position; the record held carries no output from it and no policy it is to feed.

Burundi

The telecommunications regulator told a workshop that very few Burundians use the internet. It characterised the level without publishing a figure, so the finding the base can carry is the regulator's own [statement that use is low](#), not a percentage.

DR Congo

This is the month's clearest movement with both ends dated. The universal service fund [signed subsidy conventions with four operators on 8 August for a first tranche of 40 localities, about 258,000 people](#), against a national diagnostic published the day before finding nearly 3,000 uncovered localities — about 4.3m people — and coverage of 77% 2G, 68% 3G and 57% 4G. [A second phase of 300 sites is planned, with a 2030 target of 3,000 localities and 100 digital community centres](#). An unfunded fund at the window's start, a first funded tranche at its end; no per-locality budget or fund appropriation figure is held. The diagnostic's own spread is wide: [coverage runs from about 98% in Kinshasa to 14% in Tshuapa and 28% in each of Kwango and Sud-Ubangi](#), and the fund is [drafting a national strategy that prioritises investment by coverage gap, population, economic activity, public infrastructure and geography, naming the Lobito, National and Peace corridors as its three strategic routes and shared passive infrastructure as its approach](#). No adoption date, budget or target is published for it.

Egypt

Accessibility followed a similar pattern of demonstration without obligation. On 4 August the ICT ministry published an accessibility toolbar on every page of its own site under a presidential initiative, executed by the ministry's academy for persons with disabilities, whose mandate is to propagate the standards to other government bodies. No deadline, list of bound entities, conformance level or audit route was stated ([ministry account](#)).

Eswatini

On 6 August the [Macetjeni Integrated Business, Employment and Innovation Hub](#) was launched in the Lubombo Region, the second after Pigg's Peak, established by the Small Enterprises Development Company with ESCCOM and UNDP. A third hub is in preparation for Shiselweni, with no start date, provider or cohort size given.

Gambia

The schools' side of the divide has a figure for the first time, and it is small: [13.2% of schools have internet available for teaching, across a system of 830,895 learners](#), on the education ministry's own statistics summary. No breakdown by level, region or school type comes with it — but it is the denominator every education-technology programme in this report has been running without.

Ghana

At a policy dialogue on 29 July the regulator said an existing hotspot authorisation [could found a dedicated community-network regime](#), with no timetable, consultation or draft announced; a civil-society policy lead placed four other African states ahead of Ghana on enabling frameworks.

The [draft digital economy and innovation development fund bill](#) would also convert the universal-access fund into a wider innovation and skills fund, with the fate of the rural-access earmark unestablished.

Existing money went the other way. An implementing partner's account of 12 August reports that [connectivity and digital-inclusion work in Ghana slowed or stopped after the American aid wind-down of 2025, in which 83% of the agency's programmes were cut](#), the multi-funder Women in the Digital Economy Fund losing its American component while the parts other funders backed continued. No replacement funder is named and no Ghanaian figure is given.

The rural project's own numbers reached the base on 5 September. [1,400 of 2,016 rural telephony sites are live and the universal-access fund carries a GHS 30m allocation for the project in 2026](#), with the minister directing that every site be upgraded to at least 4G on the ground that 2G and 3G no longer carry the services the sites exist to deliver, a directive [repeated on an Eastern Region site inspection the next day](#). It carries no timetable, cost or contracting route, and 616 sites are not yet live. Above it, [smartphone penetration is put at 71.8% in June 2026 against 27.5% a decade earlier](#) — the minister's figure, on a different base from the household survey the record already holds.

Guinea-Bissau

The first measurement of adolescent access the base holds is academic rather than official. A [survey of 2,039 Bissau adolescents finds computer and internet access limited and unevenly distributed, skewed against girls and against pupils in state schools, with the pandemic having exposed rather than created the gap](#). It covers the capital rather than the country, and nothing official exists at any date to set beside it — which is why a doctoral thesis is the best evidence this report has on who among the young can get online.

Kenya

The KenSafeSpace digital-rights coalition [closed on 28 July](#) after 30 months on a EUR 1.3m grant, reporting 18,000 people reached directly and 133 defenders trained, with its 49 members continuing unfunded; a successor programme opened the same day training 150 justice-sector officials on digital evidence.

The larger withdrawal is American. An implementing partner's account published on 12 August reports that [work bringing connectivity and digital inclusion to remote Kenyan counties slowed or stopped after the 2025 wind-down](#), in which 83% of the agency's programmes were cut, and that [the multi-funder Women in the Digital Economy Fund lost its American component while the parts other funders backed continued](#). What is described as lost is not the money alone but the convening: the party that got competitors, ministries and communities into the same project. No replacement funder is named, and no figure for the Kenyan share is stated.

Domestic provision was restated in the same fortnight. The regulator's Universal Service Fund [put a target of 120,000 people across 19 counties over three years on its Digital Skilling Project](#), aimed at unserved and underserved areas and framed as the skills half of a connectivity programme. It is a target stated at a stakeholders' workshop: no budget line, delivery partner, county list or start date accompanies it, and the fund's own FY2025/26 account is still unpublished.

Malawi

The universal service fund is in operation and funded from the regulator's annual budget allocation, and its [director general stated existing funding levels remain insufficient to meet the country's connectivity needs](#). A school connectivity project runs under it and the secondary-school skills work above is stated to draw on it. No income, balance or disbursement figure is held for any year, and the base holds no regulator annual report or fund account at all.

Mozambique

The inclusion figures move in opposite directions depending on which one is read. The central bank's 2025 report puts the [financial inclusion index at 36.4 points, classified moderate, with Cabo Delgado rising from 23.3 to 25.8](#) — a national index that did not move while access points rose 36%. Underneath it the [gender gap in access to credit stands at 34% women against 66% men](#), and women's mobile money holding rose 24% over the same period. The account gap is narrowing while the credit gap widens.

The funding aimed at those gaps shrank in the same window. An implementing partner's account of 12 August reports that [connectivity and digital-inclusion work in Mozambique slowed or stopped after the American aid wind-down of 2025, in which 83% of the agency's programmes were cut](#), the multi-funder Women in the Digital Economy Fund losing its American component while the parts other funders backed continued. No replacement funder is named and no Mozambican figure is given.

Niger

One training cohort is the whole of the window's movement here. [500 women working in agri-food processing and pottery at Zinder completed a ten-day programme in business management, financial planning and the use of digital financial tools, run by a mobile operator's foundation as part of an effort it is extending across several countries](#). What is established is a completed cohort, not any change in the women's access to financial services: no follow-up, account-opening figure, cost or continuation is published.

Nigeria

A global memory-chip shortage was reported on 29 July as turning device cost into a divide variable in a market that imports nearly every computer it sells.

Nothing moved on the identity gender gap, on rural access, or on the schools programme whose January 2026 completion date passed undelivered.

Senegal

The month's one inclusion measure came from the despatch box rather than a survey. Debating the critical-infrastructure bill, the telecommunications minister [told parliament that 40% of Senegalese still have no access to connectivity](#), citing a 2024 sector diagnosis of coverage gaps and unmet operator obligations. The diagnosis itself is not held, no definition of access accompanies the figure, and it is two years old at the point of its citation.

South Africa

Two measurements of the divide moved in opposite directions. Official household figures published on 28 August show [the share of households with no telephone at all down to 3.7%, about 740,000 households, from nearly 55% in 2002, with 93.8% now holding a cellphone only](#) — device access is close to universal. What it costs to use is the other half, and there the obligation is late: the communications minister [acknowledged on 27 August that the zero-rating of public-benefit websites owed under the 2022 spectrum auction is moving slowly, five months before its deadline](#), while saying he remains confident it will be met. A handset in almost every home and no free route to public-interest content is the shape of the gap the licence condition was written to close.

Uganda

A tower company [remitted UGX 20.9 billion to the universal service fund](#), its statutory 2% of gross annual revenue, at a handover reported on 31 July. [The regulator's executive director stated at the same event that half of that 2% goes to the Consolidated Fund and only half is retained to finance the fund, and put cumulative programme reach at laboratories in more than 1,000 public secondary schools](#). The period the payment covers was not published.

Money went the other way as well. An implementing partner's account of 12 August reports that [work on connectivity and digital inclusion in Uganda slowed or stopped after the American aid wind-down of 2025, in which 83% of the agency's programmes were cut](#), the multi-funder Women in the Digital Economy Fund losing its American component while the parts other funders backed continued. What is described as lost is the convening as much as the money. No replacement funder is named and no Ugandan figure is given.

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